

# On Academic Excellence as an Ethical Practice

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We talk constantly about excellence: how to cultivate it, how to evaluate it, how to recognize it, how to compete for it. We talk constantly about compliance: how to avoid misconduct, how to remain within the rules. But we rarely talk about excellence as an ethical practice.

When encountering what we call excellent science, we usually assume certain things without much reflection: that the work is not fraudulent; that data were not omitted or distorted; that those who actually did the work are the ones who signed the manuscript; that subjects were treated with dignity and care; and so on. And, of course, if it later turns out that the scientific story is fraudulent, or that credit was stolen, or that misconduct occurred, then there is no question of excellence at all.

In that sense, things appear clear. There seems to be no conceptual problem. Science is either excellent and ethical, or it is not excellent. There is no such thing as non-ethical academic excellence. But this apparent clarity rests on a failure to distinguish between two very different normative domains: on the one hand, academic laws or bylaws, and ethics, on the other.

It is absolutely forbidden to fabricate or distort data, to steal credit, to mistreat animals. These acts violate rules, regulations, and laws. They are illegal. They call for sanction. They should. But illegality is not the same as unethicity. Laws can be unethical. Breaking a law can, in certain circumstances, be an ethical act. The laws of some dark regimes are themselves unethical; resisting or violating them may be morally justified, even necessary. So there is a fundamental difference between ethical judgment and compliance with laws or institutional bylaws. Conflating the two depletes both our understanding of ethics and our conception of academic excellence.

Laws and bylaws define what is not allowed. They set a lower threshold: cross it, and you are liable to be charged and punished. An ethical code defines what is worthy. It sets a threshold for appropriateness: what we should aspire to, even when no one is watching, even when no committee will ever ask. In between these two rests the gray zone of “It is not done”, a normatively unstable space that troubles our society in recent years.

It is the second register, the register of worthiness, that I want to think about when contemplating academic excellence. Excellence in research, excellence in education, excellence in leading. Excellence lives in the ethical space. Reducing ethics to “do not violate the rules” is not a foundation for excellence. Ethics, in the deeper sense, is not an external constraint on excellence. It is part of what makes excellence.

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## What we say we are

Discussions of academic excellence and ethics can be anchored in a small set of formal texts found, in one form or another, across most research universities; not as legal instruments, but as ethical mirrors.

*Mission statements* articulate commitments to the creation and dissemination of knowledge, to education, service to society, and non-discrimination, thereby tracing moral boundaries for institutional success. They differ fundamentally from institutional branding slogans, displayed in senate halls and on university homepages, which recast success in the language of prestige, ranking, and competitive visibility. *Ethical codes* extend responsibility beyond compliance, framing integrity, freedom of inquiry, mentorship, fairness, transparency, and attentiveness to broader human and environmental consequences as constitutive of academic life. *Evaluation guidelines* affirm adherence to these values as a precondition for excellence, before listing criteria related to research quality, educational contribution, independence, and scholarly recognition. At their best, they explicitly reject the reduction of judgment to numerical proxies in favor of substantive assessment.

Taken together, these texts provide a shared institutional vocabulary against which claims of “academic excellence” may be ethically tested, allowing us to ask a simple yet demanding question: when we invoke excellence, which of these commitments are we actively honoring, and which are we quietly setting aside?

## Tensions to live by

Now I want to turn to what I see as the core of the matter: the tensions between academic excellence and ethics.

By “tensions,” I do not refer to violations, misconduct, or moral failure. Rather, I am referring to a more subtle and significant issue: structural contradictions emerge when systems that are intended to foster excellence inadvertently cultivate habits that may quietly diminish ethical worth.

In other words, the tensions are not accidental. They are produced by success-oriented academic systems everywhere. Moreover, these tensions cannot be resolved. Ethics begins precisely where such tensions are recognized, held, and actively navigated.

I will discuss three levels in which tensions manifest: the individual, the communal, and the managerial. I cannot name and discuss all possible types of tensions, so I focus on some.

## 1. Individual-level tensions

### 1.1 Boldness vs. risk asymmetry

Our evaluation guidelines rightly praise bold scientific questions. They pose the beautiful criterion: “Are the challenges that a researcher chooses worth even failing in?” It insists that not all failure is equal; that some failures are honorable because they happened while trying to answer worthy scientific questions.

But the ethical tension lies in a simple fact: failure is not distributed evenly.

For a senior, established scholar, failure can be interpreted as intellectual courage. The reputation of the scholar can absorb it. The lab can survive it. The record can contextualize it. For a junior faculty member, or for those outside dominant academic networks, the same failure may be interpreted as weakness, poor judgment, lack of rigor, or insufficient “focus.” The cost is not philosophical; it is career-shaped: fewer papers, fewer grants, fewer invitations, fewer students, fewer chances. At times, not being tenured.

So the ethical question is not whether boldness is valued in principle, but who can afford to be bold in practice. A culture of excellence that celebrates risk without attending to unequal consequences may unintentionally reward the privileged rather than the courageous.

Ethical excellence at the individual level may therefore include something that is not often named: a duty of those with security to take risks that others cannot, and (perhaps even more demanding) a duty to build conditions in which others can take meaningful risks without gambling their futures.

### 1.2 Productivity vs. mentorship integrity

We evaluate excellence through publications, grants, and visibility. At the same time, our ethical code speaks clearly about responsibility toward students and trainees: education, guidance, intellectual formation, what the Germans call *Bildung*.

Here the tension is familiar, but we should not normalize it: students can become either learners or means of production. These roles are not mutually exclusive; students can learn while producing excellent work. But the balance matters.

When speed, output, authorship counts, and grant cycles dominate evaluation, mentorship risks becoming instrumentalized. Training becomes a pipeline. Curiosity becomes a deliverable. A student’s “project” becomes a lab’s “unit of output.”

The ethical question is not whether students publish; publishing can be empowering and formative. The question is whether the rhythm of excellence allows room for learning, hesitation, and failure: all are essential components of Bildung, and all are poor performers in metrics.

A community serious about ethical excellence will ask not only, “Did your students publish?” but also: Did they learn to think? Did they learn to doubt? Did they learn to design? Did they learn to say, “This result is not convincing”? Did they learn how to be honest under pressure? Did they leave your lab stronger (intellectually, professionally, humanly) than when they entered?

We cannot measure these things as easily. But the difficulty of measurement is not permission to ignore.

### **1.3 Visibility vs. intellectual humility**

Academic excellence today is increasingly tied to visibility: invited talks, keynote lectures, editorial roles, public presence.

Visibility is not unethical; it often reflects genuine contribution. Some of it is necessary for science to circulate and for communities to form. Yet visibility quietly reshapes epistemic posture. It can be an incentive to premature certainty, rhetorical overstatement, and performative confidence. It can tempt us to smooth uncertainty into a narrative and to transform provisional findings into definitive claims, because definitive claims travel faster and farther.

Ethical excellence, by contrast, requires the capacity to say “I do not know,” to revise positions, and to remain answerable to critique. It requires a certain humility before the world, especially in disciplines where our work can shape technologies, policies, and medical practice.

So there is a tension between being seen as authoritative and remaining genuinely accountable to evidence. The more our excellence depends on being followed, the harder it becomes to remain correctable.

## **2. Communal-level tensions**

If individual ethics is about character and choices, communal ethics is about culture: what becomes normal, what becomes rewarded, what becomes silently excused.

### **2.1 Competition vs. epistemic trust**

Our system presumes that competition sharpens excellence. It can. Competition can motivate creativity, efficiency, and rigor.

But science is not merely a competitive activity. It is a trust-based epistemic enterprise. Data must be shared honestly. Methods must be reported transparently. Credit must be attributed fairly. Peer review must be done responsibly. Collaboration must be possible without fear of exploitation.

When competitive pressure intensifies, especially under conditions of scarcity, habits can emerge that are not misconduct, but are ethically corrosive: withholding data “until we publish,” even when sharing would speed truth; strategic citation that flatters networks rather than acknowledging foundations; premature publication to “secure a claim”; fragmentation of results into minimal publishable units; treating colleagues as rivals by default.

None of this is illegal; not prohibited by bylaws. But it can transform a truth-seeking culture into a survival game. The ethical tension is clear: when competition undermines trust, excellence becomes performative rather than truth-striving.

And if truth-striving erodes, excellence is empty from within.

## **2.2 Declared values vs. enacted evaluation**

As an institution, we have committed to DORA: to evaluate research on its substance rather than journal metrics. This is explicit and principled. It signals a desire to protect academic life from the tyranny of proxies.

Yet in many places, often unconsciously, habitual evaluation still privileges venue prestige as a proxy for quality. Committees and reviewers may say, “We read the work,” but then treat certain journal names as decisive. They may say, “We value substance,” but then assume that substance is reliably encoded in impact factor.

This gap between declared values and enacted behavior is ethically significant. It teaches junior colleagues that official commitments are aspirational, while real judgments follow older, tacit rules.

Ethical excellence requires not only good declarations, but alignment between values and daily evaluative practice. It is achieved by the boring, repeated discipline of: reading the work, arguing about it, recognizing diversity of contribution, rewarding depth even when it comes in unfamiliar form.

Otherwise, the ethical code becomes a dead letter, and evaluation reduces to power.

## **2.3 Silence mistaken for collegiality**

Academic communities value harmony and collegiality. These are real goods. We need cooperation, mutual respect, and a sense that we are on the same side.

But collegiality carries an ethical risk: silence in the face of problematic, even if legal, behavior.

When raising concerns is perceived as disloyal or disruptive, ethical responsibility is inverted. The preservation of superficial harmony comes at the expense of integrity. People learn to keep their heads down. They learn that speaking honestly costs more than staying quiet.

Over time, it corrodes trust more deeply than open disagreement ever could.

A community that wants ethical excellence must protect the capacity to speak, especially when the issue is not a scandal, but a pattern; scandals find their ways to be known, patterns are less so: patterns of mentoring that instrumentalize students; patterns of exclusion that are never “official,” but always felt; patterns of evaluation that claim fairness but operate through informal networks; patterns of work culture that burn people out while praising “excellence.”

Ethical cultures do not eliminate conflict. They make conflict speakable, accountable, and aimed toward repair rather than punishment.

### **3. Managerial and leadership-level tensions**

Now let me shift to the domain of leadership, because faculty are all leaders: of labs, programs, committees, centers, initiatives.

#### **3.1 Metrics vs. mission**

Institutions are increasingly governed by metrics: rankings, funding volume, citation indices, publication counts, “international visibility.”

These are not irrelevant. They can correlate with meaningful achievement. But they are not identical to the stated mission of education, knowledge dissemination, service to society, breadth of inquiry, and non-discrimination.

Metrics are not unethical per se; their ethical status depends on their exclusivity and dominance. Ethical tension emerges when what is measurable gradually displaces what is meaningful. Excellence then comes to be defined by what travels well in spreadsheets, rather than by contribution to knowledge, education, or intellectual life.

And here is the trickiness: nobody explicitly decides to base evaluation on metrics. It happens quietly. It happens when committees begin to speak as if metrics are reality rather than indicators. It happens when leadership conversations become dominated by “how we look,” rather than “what we do.”

Leadership ethics begins with resisting the quiet takeover of mission by metrics. This does not mean ignoring metrics. It means refusing to let them become the only language we speak about value.

### **3.2 Freedom of research vs. Institutional bias**

Our ethical code celebrates freedom of research as the soul of academic endeavor. Yet institutions inevitably make choices: they express preferences among areas, individuals, and initiatives. Choices are unavoidable. Resources and attention are limited; opportunities are time-sensitive; reputation, political, and financial pressures shape what is encouraged and what is avoided. These conditions invite bias, often quietly steering research toward preferred directions.

The ethical tension emerges not through overt prohibition, but through subtle discouragement of inquiry perceived as risky. Not illegal, not unethical, but uncomfortable. It is easy to say, “Of course people are free to research what they want.” Harder to notice the everyday signals that communicate institutional preference: what receives internal funding; what is publicly praised; which projects are labeled “strategic”; which voices are invited into discussion; which forms of critique are tolerated.

Institutions rarely censor outright. More often, they simply do not protect. By doing so, they allow risk to concentrate on the most vulnerable. That, too, is an ethical choice.

The ethical danger arises when institutional preferences operate automatically, while retaining the language of neutrality and freedom. Discrimination is then seldom explicit; it becomes normalized. Freedom of research remains formally intact, yet inquiry that challenges institutional comfort is quietly discouraged. Support, recognition, and protection are distributed selectively, eroding fairness and hollowing freedom.

Ethical leadership therefore requires: transparency about institutional preferences, naming priorities rather than pretending neutrality; procedural fairness in how decisions are made, documented, and reviewed; care for those systematically left unprotected, and for whether such exclusions align with the institution’s mission and values.

Bias in research support is not unethical. Bias that proceeds without self-examination becomes dangerous. Over time, it undermines trust in leadership.

### **3.3 Management, government, and regulatory power**

There is one further tension that must be named explicitly, particularly from the standpoint of academic leadership: the moral tension inherent in management’s interaction with government and regulatory authorities.

Academic institutions do not operate in isolation. They depend on public funding, legal frameworks, regulatory approval, and political goodwill. Engagement with government is unavoidable and ethically legitimate.

Yet this very proximity generates a persistent moral tension.

On the one hand, institutional leadership bears responsibility for securing resources, ensuring compliance, and protecting the institution from legal and political harm. On the other hand, the university carries an obligation that cannot be delegated: to preserve intellectual autonomy, freedom of inquiry, and the capacity for critique, including critique of the very authorities on which it depends.

The ethical risk here is gradual accommodation: the quiet internalization of external constraints as if they were intrinsic necessities. When regulatory logic begins to shape research priorities, hiring decisions, or permissible forms of expression, autonomy is not abolished; it is eroded.

This tension is most acute when demands are legal, procedurally correct, and framed in the language of national interest, security, efficiency, or public accountability. Under such conditions, resistance can appear irresponsible or naïve.

Yet ethical leadership sometimes requires sustaining institutional discomfort in order to preserve the conditions of independent thought.

The moral question for academic management is therefore not whether to engage with government and regulators, but how to do so without allowing compliance and practicality to harden into self-censorship.

Ethical excellence in academic management means working with external authorities without being taken over by them. This requires keeping a clear line between cooperation and loss of independence, and actively maintaining and defending that line.

## **Concluding remarks**

None of the above tensions imply wrongdoing. They are structural features of excellence-driven systems, and they cannot be eliminated without eliminating ambition itself. Ethics does not consist in denying such tensions, nor in imagining their resolution. It consists in recognizing them, naming how they operate, and taking responsibility for how we live with them.

Academic excellence, understood ethically, is therefore not only about achievement. It is about how achievement is pursued, distributed, taught, and governed under conditions that are inherently tension-laden.

I would like to conclude not with answers, but with questions. Not questions aimed at diagnosing failure, but questions intended to invite collective reflection within academic life; questions appropriate to institutions that seek to combine scientific ambition with educational and communal responsibility.

As we think together about excellence, we might ask: Which of these tensions do we explicitly acknowledge, and which do we leave implicit? Which do we treat as productive constraints, and which do we allow to drift, unexamined, into habit? Which are transmitted to students as reflective challenges, and which as unquestioned facts of “how academia works”? Where do our declared values and our routine judgments pull in different directions, and how do we justify that gap? Who in our community is buffered from the costs of these tensions, and who carries them directly?

And finally, an overarching question I leave with you:

*What would it look like, in the academic community, to treat ethics not as a constraint on excellence, but as the space that constitutes excellence?*

If we can keep that space alive, through how we mentor, how we evaluate, how we lead, and how we disagree, then academic excellence becomes not merely something we achieve, but something we can stand behind.